



Maximised Window

edge. This can be used to compare and copy data across different locations by dragging them to opposite sides of your screen.

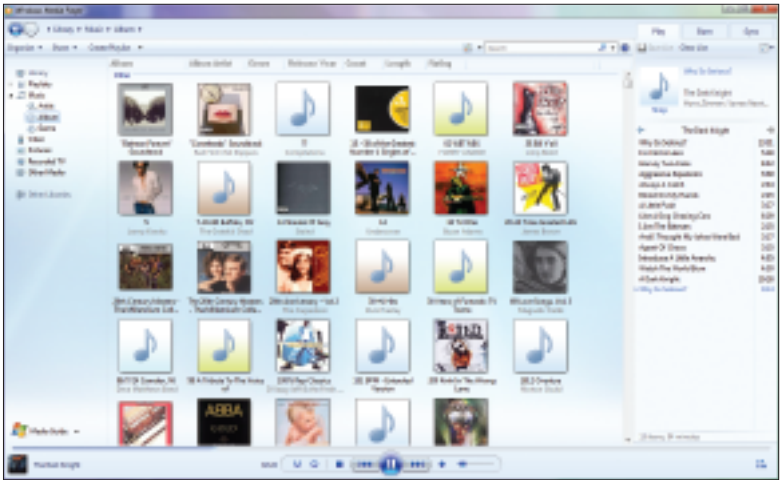
Libraries

The promise of WinFS to bring intelligence, relevance, and relation to your data was so badly needed that we were extremely disappointed when the feature was unceremoniously dropped from Vista – likely to be never heard from again. Libraries, while nowhere near a relational database, somewhat takes the sting away from losing WinFS. The concept is simple – you have similar data spread across drives, folders, partitions, etc. – so why not logically store them under a single virtual folder? Windows 7 Beta does just that and we’re thankful for it. You can thus have libraries collating pictures, videos, music, documents, and create and define your own libraries to boot. It’s a great way to store and access information.

When you pin Windows Explorer to the taskbar, a right-click on its icon shows you your current libraries. These can be permanently pinned as well. Thus giving you access to your entire content straight from the taskbar itself.

Another welcome addition is that the library is automatically shared across supported appli-

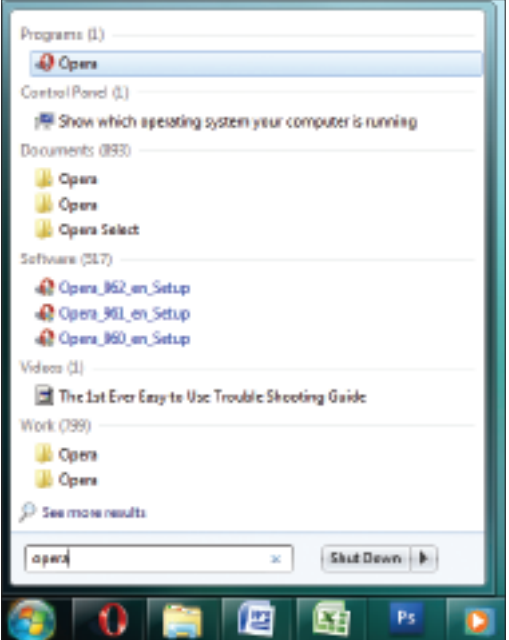
Libraries are shared across applications



cations. No longer will you need to create independent libraries of your music / videos / photographs under different programs – Winamp, Picasa, Media Player, Media Jukebox, and so on. If a program supports Libraries, it will immediately and automatically gain access to all your content. A drawback here is that there is currently no apparent way to exclude content from being listed in a library, so sensitive data also shows up with everything else.

Search

Search under this Beta is fixed in three ways: (1) it’s fast, so we actually use it; (2) it takes up the

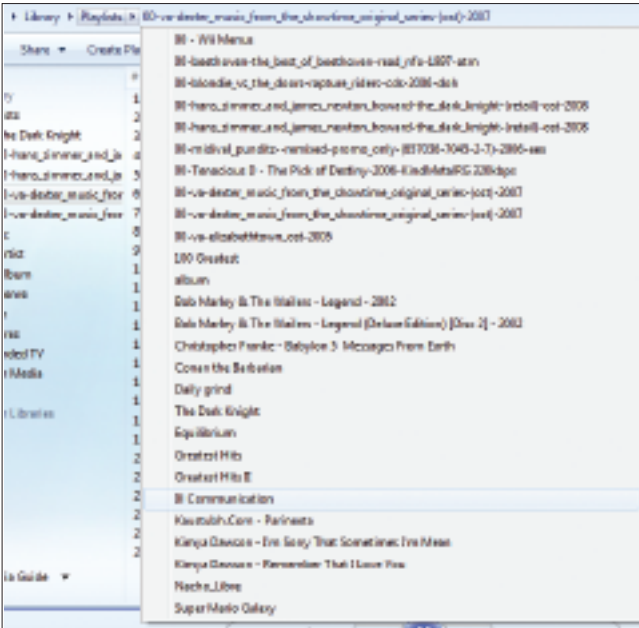


Faster search relevant results

entire Start menu width, so it doesn’t look messy; (3) search results now expose pre-set filters that go a long way to refining a search query. Search in general is now much more usable.

Windows Media Player

This is a much snappier avatar of WMP. It also supports a wider range of codecs right off the bat, although not enough to throw away your favourite codec pack. While playing music or video files, WMP starts a minimal interface showing just the media and playback controls – a no-nonsense approach that is appreciated. From the ‘Now Playing’ view you can switch to the more traditional Library view which breaks down WMP into three panes. Left is where you navigate through your libraries. Centre is where you find a library’s content, and on the right you have a task pane. The right pane offers frequent tasks – Play, Burn and Sync. It’s a much cleaner interface that takes a while to get used to because old habits die hard... Notably, you can hover over a track’s name in the middle



Playlists are auto populated by WMP



WMP taskbar preview

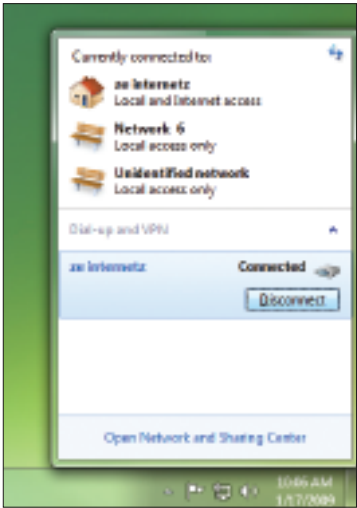
pane and WMP will play a preview of that file – only for music tracks.

Faster

Windows 7 Beta starts up faster – it also shuts down and restarts faster than our Vista Ultimate copy. Putting the Beta to sleep and waking it up is also a much faster and stable experience. This mantra of faster, extends to the entire OS as well. Aero no longer feels sluggish to use. We’ve had mixed results copying files across media – another common complaint with Vista. At times, this is much faster (took us an entire 120 seconds less to copy 8GB of files under Windows 7, as compared to Vista). Similarly, it feels just as slow (note that the latter is not a scientific conclusion, just a feeling). On the whole, if you were keeping away from Vista because of its speed, Windows 7 Beta promises to fix that issue.

Networking

Right off the taskbar you can manage your network connections. One click on a “network”



Above: Network and Sharing Center
Left: Managing network connections

icon next to the volume control icon opens a pop-up. From here you can open the Network and Sharing Center, get an overview of the networks you are connected to, and connect and disconnect yourself over dial-up, VPN, or Wi-Fi. The Network and Sharing Center is also stream-

lined – letting you manage, setup, troubleshoot your networks.

New to Windows 7 Beta is the HomeGroup, which is exactly what it sounds like – you can use it to connect your home PCs together, letting you share photos, music, videos and so on. When you setup a HomeGroup, you can select the libraries and devices that you want to share. This group can be password-protected, and you can set access permissions as well. Computers must be running Windows 7 to participate in a HomeGroup.

Action Center

This is where all those irritating pop-up balloons have gone to die. Good riddance too. Notifications are much more subdued under this Beta. No longer does it feel like the OS is screaming for attention every time a file stubs its toe. The Action Center is a tiny flag icon sitting next to the volume and network icons on the taskbar. From here, you can review system messages and take steps to resolve pending issues. The Center breaks info down into two categories: Security, wherein falls Firewall, Update, virus, spyware and similar settings; and Maintenance, where you can backup and restore data, and check for



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